“Where Does Mom Go From Here?”

The questions families ask when a parent is leaving the hospital, with plain general answers and who to ask about your own.

Mom is in the hospital or in rehab, discharge is being discussed, and the same handful of questions keeps coming up in the hallway and on the phone with your family. These are the ones families ask most, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about Mom in particular. Most of these questions depend on her condition, her coverage and her state, so each answer says what can be said in general and who can answer the rest.

1 What does “level of care” actually mean?

The public sources we checked don't define it. People generally use it for how much help someone needs, what kind, and where it can be given. Most long-term care is help with the basic personal tasks of everyday life, not medical care, and it can be provided at home, in the community or in a facility. Nursing homes provide the most comprehensive range of services, including nursing care and 24-hour supervision. [1] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** someone uses the phrase about Mom and you're not sure what they mean. Ask them to name the help she would need and where it could be given.

2 What level of care does Mom need right now?

That is for the people who assess her, and no guide can answer it. Discharge planning is described as a process that determines the kind of care a patient needs after leaving the hospital. In a skilled nursing facility, a team from different medical fields plans the care from her health needs, her doctor's orders and its own periodic assessments. Your part is what they can't see: what you've watched her do and not do. [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a plan is being made and nobody has asked what you've seen, or what help is available to her.

3 Do we get a say in the plan?

In general, yes. Medicare.gov says that in a skilled nursing facility the patient, the family or someone acting on the patient's behalf can help plan the care, and it suggests telling the staff you want to be involved. The Family Caregiver Alliance's guide adds a practical point: ask for all instructions and guidance in writing. [4] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you don't know who is handling the planning. Ask any nurse who your point person is; it may be a discharge planner, a social worker or a nurse.

4 Where should Mom go after the hospital or rehab?

In general, care can be given at home, in the community or in a facility, and for many people a blended approach works best. A discharge plan includes planning for a homecoming or for a transfer to another care facility. Which of those fits Mom depends on the care she needs and the help that is available, and that is a conversation with her care team. [2] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've been asked to choose a facility and you don't know what the choices are. One question the Family Caregiver Alliance suggests is “Who will select the facility?”

5 Can Mom go home?

We can't tell you, and a guide shouldn't try. What can be said in general is that care at home may come from family members and friends, or from a nurse, an aide or a therapist who comes to the home. Discharge planners should talk with you about your willingness and ability to provide care. Another question the Family Caregiver Alliance suggests is “Do I need to hire additional help?” [2] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** going home is being planned around help you're not sure you can give. Tell the discharge staff about your limits, plainly.

6 What's the difference between assisted living, memory care and a nursing home?

MedlinePlus describes assisted living as housing and services for people who need some help with daily care but who do not need the medical care that a nursing home provides. Medicare.gov describes nursing homes as facilities for people who usually need 24-hour care. The sources we checked don't define memory care; MedlinePlus notes that assisted living residents are usually older adults, including people with Alzheimer's or other types of dementia, so ask each place what its memory care includes. [5] [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're trying to work out which of these fits Mom. That is a question for the care team who has assessed her.

7 What's the difference between skilled care and custodial care?

Medicare.gov describes skilled care as nursing and therapy care that can only be safely and effectively performed by, or under the supervision of, professionals or technical personnel. Long-term care, which it says is also called custodial care, is for people who need help with activities of daily living, like bathing, dressing or eating. You'll hear both words when coverage is discussed, so it helps to know which one the staff mean. [7] [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell which kind of care Mom is receiving now. Ask her nurse or therapist to say.

8 What happens when Medicare stops covering skilled nursing care?

It depends on Mom's situation and her state, and we can't tell you from here. In general, Medicare.gov says the facility is required to do an assessment when Part A skilled nursing facility coverage ends, even if the person is staying, and that Medicare generally doesn't cover long-term nursing home stays unless a person is receiving skilled nursing care. What that means for where Mom stays and who pays is a question for the facility. [4] [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've heard that her coverage may be changing. Ask the facility's social worker or business office what is changing, how you'll be told, and what they would need from you.

9 Who pays for all this?

It depends on the care, the setting, Mom's insurance and her state. Insurance, including Medicare, does not pay for all services after a hospital discharge, and the amount a person could owe depends on things such as other insurance and the type of facility. Medicaid is a joint federal and state program, and its eligibility rules and covered services vary from state to state. Take payment questions directly to the hospital or facility, her insurer or Medicare. [3] [6] [8]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the question is about Medicaid. Bring it to your Medicaid planner; the answer depends on the rules in Mom's state and on her own situation.

10 We're already paying for Mom's care ourselves. Is that unusual?

No, at least where nursing homes are concerned: Medicare.gov says most people who enter nursing homes start by paying for their care out-of-pocket. What care costs depends on the type and duration of care, the provider and where you live, and facilities may add extra charges beyond the basic room, food and housekeeping. Whether the arrangement fits Mom's needs is for the people who assess her. What you can do now is write down what you pay, to whom, and what it includes. [9] [10]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're wondering how long the current arrangement can continue. Bring what you've written down to your Medicaid planner.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Mom herself: what care she needs, where she should go, what Medicare or Medicaid will cover for her, or what her care will cost. Those answers come from the people who assess her and from professionals who know her state. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know which of your questions have a general answer and who can answer the rest. The care interview is where the questions become about Mom: it walks you through her situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Where Can You Receive Care?
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
4. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Assessments & care plans in Skilled Nursing Facilities
5. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Assisted Living: MedlinePlus

6. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Nursing Home Coverage
7. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), SNF Care Coverage
8. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid
9. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
10. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Costs of Care

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